Wishes and regrets

Objective: Express wishes about the present and regrets about the past using *I wish* and *If only*, and choose the correct tense after them.

In two lines: After *wish / if only* we move the verb one tense back. The past simple shows a wish about now; the past perfect shows a regret about the past.

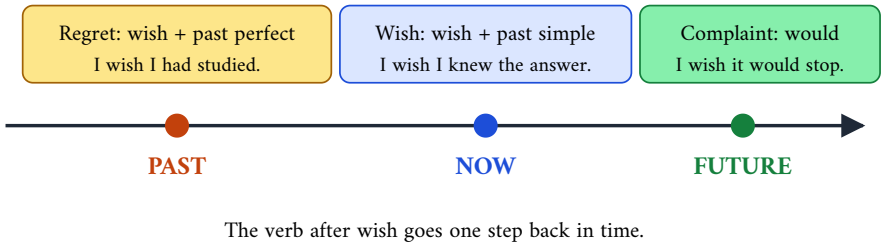


Figure 1: Choosing the tense after *wish* according to the time of the wish.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Present wish:** subject + wish + past simple: *I wish I had more friends.* (Fact: I don't have many friends.)
2. With the verb *be*, we can use **were** for all persons: *I wish he were here.*
3. **Past regret:** subject + wish + past perfect: *She wishes she hadn't lied.* (Fact: she lied.)
4. **If only** has the same structure but is stronger and more emotional: *If only I had listened!*
5. **wish + would** expresses annoyance or a desire for someone else to change: *I wish you would help me.*
6. **Ability:** use *could* for a present wish: *I wish I could swim.*

🟢 Examples

1. Rewrite: I'm sorry I didn't visit my grandmother. **Answer:** I wish I had visited my grandmother. **Explanation:** regret about the past, so past perfect with opposite meaning.
2. Rewrite: It's a pity we live far from our neighbours. **Answer:** If only we didn't live far from our neighbours. **Explanation:** present situation, so past simple.
3. Complete: My brother never shares his things. I wish he (share) them. **Answer:** would share.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Keeping the original tense: *I wish I have a car* instead of *I wish I had a car*.
- Forgetting to reverse the meaning: *I didn't help* becomes *I wish I had helped*, not *hadn't helped*.
- Using *I wish I would…* about yourself; use *could* or the past simple instead.
- Using the past simple for past regrets: *I wish I studied yesterday* is wrong.

🟡 Quick review

- Now: wish + past simple / could.
- Past: wish + had + past participle.
- Someone else's behaviour: wish + would.
- If only = a stronger wish, same tenses.
- Always reverse positive and negative.

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